

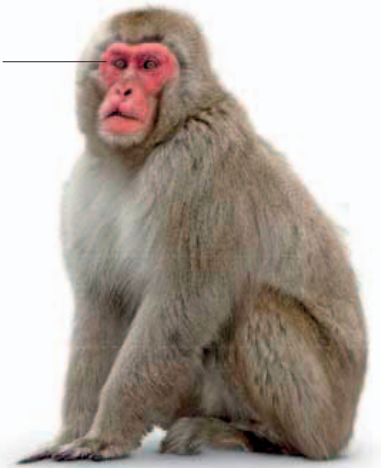
◁ WARMING UP

Japanese macaques regularly exploit hot springs to keep warm and rid themselves of parasites. High-ranking individuals within a troop are allowed greater privileges at the springs.

Japanese macaque

Macaca fuscata

face darker
red during
mating season



Native to the Japanese islands, the Japanese macaque is also known as the snow monkey—with good reason. This short-tailed monkey lives in snowy regions farther north than any other nonhuman primate species on the planet. Northern Honshu in particular can be snow-covered for a third of the year, and the Japanese macaque's dense gray-brown coat, which covers its entire body except the face and rump, grows thicker as the temperature falls. This allows it to survive temperatures as low as -4°F (-20°C).

Its habitat ranges from subtropical forests in southern Japan to subarctic woods in the north. The females spend more time in trees, while males prefer to stay on the ground; however, all Japanese macaques sleep in trees whenever possible to avoid predators such as feral dogs. They are true omnivores, although they eat more plants than animals. Their preferred diet consists of seasonal fruit, nuts, seeds, and leaves, but they will eat fungi, insects, shellfish, fish, roots, and even soil, for minerals, when necessary.

Inherited rank

The males are slightly larger and heavier than females, and social groups, known as troops, are made up of both sexes. However, the rank, or standing, in a troop

passes from mothers to daughters. One troop may have several of these “matrilines” arranged in a hierarchy, with members of one matriline outranking all lower-ranking matrilines. Males within a troop also follow a dominance system, led by an alpha male. Females stay in their troops for life, but males join different ones when they reach sexual maturity.

Female Japanese macaques decide which males to mate with, and will not necessarily choose an alpha male. Mating takes place on the ground or in trees, and a single infant (or twins in rare cases) is born five to six months later. Infants begin foraging for themselves at around seven weeks, but they depend on their mothers for about 18 months. Grandmothers sometimes raise their abandoned grandchildren—the first nonhuman primate known to do so.

Versatile communicator

An intelligent species, Japanese macaques use a number of sounds and calls to communicate, as well as to alert troop members to danger. They also learn behavioral techniques from each other, such as bathing in hot springs, rolling snowballs, and washing food in fresh water before dipping it in salt water to enhance the taste.

Japanese macaque troops in **different locations have different accents**, just like humans do

◁ WINTER FORAGING

The diet of Japanese macaques changes with the seasons—in winter they eat mainly tree bark and buds.

- ↔ 19–28 in (47–72 cm)
- ⚖ 18–24 lb (8–11 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Plants, insects, shellfish
- 🏠 🍌 🍌 🍌



Japan